

# EKA IT-osakonna juhataja Interview Preparation

**Date:** January 6, 2026 at 10:00

**Location:** Põhja pst 7, II korrus, D206.1 (Personaliosakond)

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## Executive Summary

**Unique Position:** Returning to the exact role I held 2009-2012 at the same institution. I built the foundational infrastructure (LAN, email, Entu) that likely still serves EKA today.

### Position Title Analysis:

The title “**IT-osakonna juhataja**” (Head of IT Department) may be **inflated relative to actual scope**:

- “**Osakond**” (**Department**) suggests substantial organizational unit with sub-teams/functions
- **Reality:** 4-person direct reports (3 support + 1 data protection), no layers, no sub-teams
- **International equivalent:** “IT Manager” or “IT Team Lead” more accurate than “IT Director/Department Head”

### Title Mismatch Implications:

1. **Estonian public sector tradition** - Formal titles standard regardless of team size
2. **Aspirational vs. actual** - Title reflects desired strategic role, not operational reality
3. **Expectation signal** - May indicate unrealistic scope expectations (strategic planning + hands-on work with 4-person team)
4. **Organizational positioning** - Title gives authority/seat at table, even if team is small

### What This Reveals:

- EKA treats IT as strategic function (good: leadership voice)
- But team size doesn't match strategic ambitions (red flag: capacity mismatch)
- You'll need to navigate between “department head” expectations and “team lead” resources

### Key Strengths:

- 100% match on all required qualifications
- Previous 3-year tenure as EKA IT-osakonna juht
- Proven track record of major infrastructure projects (700+ users)
- Deep institutional knowledge and context
- 20+ years continuous IT experience including 6 years team/department leadership

### Key Challenges to Address:

- E-ITS (Estonian Information Security Standard) implementation - gap acknowledged
  - 13-year absence from institution (2012-2025) - what has changed?
  - Digital transformation landscape evolution since 2012
  - Current IT team structure and dynamics
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## Current EKA Context (2025)

### Institution Overview

#### Size & Scope:

- **1,144 students** (as of Nov 2023: 623 BA, 129 integrated, 319 MA, 73 PhD)
- **279 employees** (128 academic staff, 151 support staff, 20 professors)
- **9% international academic staff**
- **~721 hourly paid teaching staff**
- **QS ranking:** Top 150 worldwide in art & design
- **New building:** Kalamaja campus (Põhja pst 7) - modern facilities

### Academic Structure

#### Faculties:

- Architecture and Urban Planning
- Design and Innovation
- Fine Arts
- Applied Arts
- Art History and Visual Culture

**Programs:** Animation, Fashion Design, Product Design, Glass, Ceramics, Painting, Graphic Design, Interior Architecture, etc.

### Current IT Infrastructure (2025)

#### Core Systems Identified:

- **Tahvel** - Student Information System (ÕIS)
- **Moodle** - Learning Management System
- **Wiki.js** - Internal wiki (wiki.artun.ee)
- **WebDesktop** (dok.artun.ee) - Document management
- **Digivaramu** - Digital repository (Preservica)
- **Google Workspace** - Email and collaboration (still in use from 2012 migration!)

#### Network Memberships:

- CUMULUS, EAAE, KUNO, CIRRUS, ELIA
- ~150 partner universities worldwide
- T4EU (Erasmus+ alliance)

### Strategic Priorities Observed

1. **Digital transformation** - New digital development strategy needed
2. **Information security** - E-ITS compliance implementation
3. **Inter-university cooperation** - IT collaboration working groups
4. **Sustainable EKA** - Environmental/sustainability initiatives
5. **International partnerships** - Supporting 100+ exchange agreements
6. **Research & Development** - Supporting R&D office and research centers

## Ongoing Strategic Initiatives & IT Implications

### Transform4Europe (T4EU) Alliance - Major Priority

#### Overview:

- **European university alliance** of 10 universities across Europe
- **Funding:** €14.4M continued funding secured (July 2023)
- **Timeline:** Founded November 3, 2020 (5-year anniversary just passed)
- **EKA's Leadership Role:** Coordinating "Transforming Heritage" working group
- **Partner institutions:** Germany, Spain, Estonia, Portugal, Slovenia, France, Poland, Bulgaria, Italy, Lithuania

#### Recent T4EU Activities:

- **December 2025:** First T4EU artistic research roundtables (EKA-led)
- **January 27-28, 2026:** "Spatial Dimensions" conference at EKA (upcoming!)
- Science communication workshops
- Student mobility programs across 10 universities
- Joint curriculum development initiatives
- International research collaboration

#### IT Implications (Critical for Your Role):

- **International digital collaboration infrastructure** - 10 universities need seamless connectivity
- **Student/staff mobility systems** - Exchange programs, joint courses, credit transfer
- **Research data sharing platforms** - Multi-university research collaboration tools
- **Conference/event digital infrastructure** - Virtual participation, streaming, documentation
- **Multilingual support systems** - Interface with partner universities' systems
- **Identity management** - Cross-university authentication/authorization
- **Data governance** - GDPR compliance across EU jurisdictions
- **Network capacity** - International bandwidth for collaboration
- **Video conferencing infrastructure** - Regular cross-border meetings

**Strategic Significance:** This is NOT a small side project - T4EU represents a fundamental shift toward European integration. As IT head, you'll need to ensure EKA's IT infrastructure can support this level of international collaboration. This goes far beyond basic support operations.

### Digital Repository (Digivaramu)

**Platform:** Preservica-based digital archive system **Purpose:** Long-term preservation of EKA's artistic and academic output **Content:** Student works, research outputs, institutional archives, exhibitions

#### IT Implications:

- **Storage infrastructure** - Large media files (video, high-res images, 3D models)
- **Metadata management** - Cataloging and discovery systems
- **Long-term preservation** - Format migration, bit preservation
- **Access control** - Rights management for sensitive/restricted content
- **Integration** - Connect with Tahvel (student works), research systems
- **Backup/disaster recovery** - Critical institutional memory protection

## International Student Growth

**Current:** ~140 international students (12% of student body) **Trend:** 50+ new international students annually **Impact:** Increasing diversity of technical needs and language support requirements

### IT Implications:

- **Multilingual support** - Systems, documentation, helpdesk
- **Remote access** - Students applying/enrolling from abroad
- **International payment systems** - Tuition, fees
- **Visa/immigration system integration**
- **Cultural sensitivity** - Different technical literacy levels and expectations
- **Time zone considerations** - 24/7 access needs

## Sustainability & Environmental Initiatives

### “Sustainable EKA” Program:

- Circular design education
- Environmental impact tracking
- Green campus initiatives
- Sustainable art practices

### IT Implications:

- **Environmental monitoring systems** - Energy use, waste tracking
- **Reporting platforms** - Sustainability metrics and dashboards
- **Digital-first approach** - Reduce paper, optimize resource use
- **Green IT practices** - Energy-efficient infrastructure, e-waste management
- **Carbon footprint tracking** - University-wide environmental data

## Research & Conference Activities

### Upcoming Major Event:

- **Spatial Dimensions Conference** (January 27-28, 2026) - EKA hosting international participants

### Ongoing Research:

- ADAPTER consortium (business collaboration network)
- Applied research projects
- Artistic research methodologies
- Practice-based research initiatives

### IT Implications:

- **Conference infrastructure** - Registration, streaming, hybrid participation
- **Research data management** - Storage, sharing, publication
- **Research collaboration tools** - Multi-institutional projects
- **Publication platforms** - Research outputs, digital exhibitions
- **Grant management systems** - Research funding tracking

## Key Takeaway for Interview

### The IT role at EKA is evolving from infrastructure maintenance to strategic enabler.

The T4EU alliance alone represents a massive shift - you're not just supporting one institution, you're enabling EKA's participation in a 10-university European network. This requires:

1. **Strategic thinking** - Understanding how IT enables institutional goals
2. **International perspective** - Working across borders, languages, systems
3. **Scalability planning** - Infrastructure that can grow with ambitions
4. **Partnership skills** - Collaborating with partner universities' IT teams
5. **Innovation mindset** - Finding creative solutions for complex challenges

### Questions to Ask:

- "How is EKA's IT strategy aligned with T4EU alliance requirements?"
  - "What IT infrastructure exists for the upcoming Spatial Dimensions conference in January?"
  - "How does EKA collaborate with partner universities on shared IT challenges?"
  - "What lessons have been learned from previous international conference hosting?"
  - "How is the digital repository (Digivaramu) being used and what are growth plans?"
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## What Has Changed Since 2012?

### Infrastructure Evolution (13 Years)

#### Then (2009-2012):

- Built campus LAN from scratch (700+ users)
- Migrated to Google Mail (90% cost savings)
- Implemented Entu (inventory/document management)
- Basic network infrastructure focus

#### Now (2025 - Likely State):

- Modern cloud-first architecture
- Security compliance requirements (E-ITS mandatory for public sector)
- Mobile-first user expectations
- API integrations between systems
- Advanced authentication (TARA integration)
- Data privacy regulations (GDPR)
- Cybersecurity threats significantly evolved

## Technology Landscape Shifts

### Development Practices:

- Git/GitHub standard (2012: SVN)
- CI/CD pipelines expected (2012: manual deployment)
- Containerization (Docker/Kubernetes)
- Infrastructure as Code
- Cloud services dominant (AWS/Azure/GCP)

## Security Requirements:

- E-ITS mandatory for public institutions
- Multi-factor authentication standard
- Regular security audits required
- Incident response procedures
- Data protection impact assessments

## User Expectations:

- 24/7 availability expected
  - Mobile access essential
  - Self-service portals
  - Real-time collaboration tools
  - Accessibility requirements
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## Critical Challenges Ahead

### 1. E-ITS Implementation (Priority #1)

**What is E-ITS?** Estonian Information Security Standard (Eesti Infoturbestandard) - **MANDATORY** framework for ALL public sector organizations including universities. Based on German BSI IT-Grundschutz methodology.

### Critical Understanding (See eits-deep-dive-research.md for full analysis):

E-ITS is **NOT just an IT project** - it's an **organizational transformation** requiring:

- **Top management commitment** (Rector/Board must lead, not just IT)
- **Cross-functional involvement** (all process owners, not just IT department)
- **Systematic risk management** across ALL business processes
- **Information Security Management System (ISMS) lifecycle**
- **Comprehensive documentation** of policies, procedures, measures
- **Continuous monitoring and improvement** (ongoing, not one-time)
- **Security culture transformation** (training for ALL staff, not just IT)

### Legal Foundation:

- Küberturvalisuse seadus (Cybersecurity Act) § 3
- Minister's Decree No. 101 (December 16, 2022)
- Latest version: 2024 (updated August 28, 2025)
- Regulatory authority: Riigi Infosüsteemi Amet (RIA)
- Source: <https://eits.ria.ee/>

### Core Components:

1. **E-ITS Nõuded** - ISMS requirements (11 sections, full lifecycle)
2. **Etalonturbe kataloog** - Reference security catalog (800+ measures in modules)
3. **Auditeerimiseeskiri** - Audit guidelines (external compliance verification)

### Implementation Approaches:

- **Põhiturve** (Basic Security) - Normal protection requirements, essential baseline
- **Standardturve** (Standard Security) - High/very high requirements, □ ISO 27001 alignment

- **Tuumikuturve** (Core Security) - Focused on critical processes only

### **EKA Reality - Likely Needs Standardturve:**

- Public sector university = mandatory compliance
- Student/research data = high protection requirements
- T4EU international partnerships = complex data sharing
- Financial/HR systems = high protection requirements

### **Realistic Timeline for EKA:**

- **Phase 1 (Prep):** 2-3 months - Management commitment, appoint lead, initial training
- **Phase 2 (Planning):** 4-6 months - Policy, risk assessment, scope definition
- **Phase 3 (Basic):** 6-12 months - Basic measures implementation
- **Phase 4 (Standard):** 12-18 months additional - Standard measures, external risk analysis
- **Phase 5 (Audit):** 3-6 months - Internal review, external audit

**Total: 2.5-4 years** for full standard-level implementation

### **Effort Required:**

- IT Department: 30-50% of one FTE continuously (not one-time project!)
- Information Security Lead: 20-30% FTE (likely IT head role)
- Process Owners: 10-20% during implementation
- Management: Quarterly reviews + policy approvals
- All Staff: Annual training (4-8 hours)
- External Consultant: Recommended 50-100 hours total

### **EKA Advantages:**

- **Bert Blös** (Data Protection Officer) already in place - essential E-ITS resource!
- GDPR compliance work underway - overlaps with E-ITS requirements
- Existing digital systems (Tahvel, Moodle, etc.) - defined scope
- Inter-university cooperation opportunity - learn from other Estonian universities

### **EKA Challenges:**

- **Small team** (5 people) for large scope (1,144 students + 279 staff)
- **Team likely saturated** with operations - no capacity for E-ITS strategic work
- **T4EU complexity** - 10-university alliance, cross-border data, likely high protection requirements
- **Legacy infrastructure** unknown (2012 systems may still exist - technical debt?)
- **Limited budget** - public sector constraints, procurement regulations

### **Your Gap (Honest Assessment):**

- **NO direct E-ITS implementation experience** - this is real
- **BUT:**
  - Strong general IT security background (20+ years infrastructure, network security)
  - Public sector experience (Justiitsministeerium, understand compliance frameworks)
  - University environment knowledge (EKA 2009-2012, understand academic culture)
  - Team leadership experience (can coordinate cross-functional effort)
  - Research capability (completed deep E-ITS analysis before interview)

## **Your Approach (Demonstrate Maturity):**

"E-ITS is mandatory for EKA and will be a major strategic priority. I've researched the framework thoroughly - it's based on BSI IT-Grundschutz, requires top management commitment, and involves systematic risk management across organizational processes.

While I don't have direct implementation experience, I understand E-ITS is fundamentally organizational transformation, not just IT configuration. My approach would be:

1. **Partner with certified E-ITS consultant** for initial assessment and planning
2. **Engage in inter-university IT cooperation** to learn from peers (TalTech, TÜ, etc.)
3. **Build cross-functional E-ITS working group** with process owners and Bert Blös
4. **Ensure top management understands their essential leadership role** (not delegate to IT alone)
5. **Take phased approach** - basic security first, systematic build toward standard compliance
6. **Set realistic expectations** - 2.5-4 years minimum, requires sustained resources

EKA has critical foundations: Bert Blös as data protection officer, existing digital systems, GDPR compliance underway. We can build on these. But success requires management commitment and adequate resources - I won't promise what I can't deliver."

## **Critical Questions to Ask:**

### **Current State:**

1. "What is EKA's current E-ITS compliance level? Has any assessment been done?"
2. "Has there been board-level discussion about E-ITS requirements and timeline?"
3. "What role does Bert Blös play beyond GDPR - is he involved in broader security management?"
4. "What security incidents or concerns have been raised recently?"

**Management Support:** 5. "How does the rector view information security? Is there awareness that E-ITS requires top management commitment?" 6. "What budget exists or can be allocated for security initiatives beyond daily operations?" 7. "Is there IT governance structure or committee for strategic IT matters?"

**Team Capacity (CRITICAL):** 8. "What percentage of IT team's time is reactive support vs. strategic projects?" 9. "Has there been consideration of adding E-ITS/security-focused capacity?" 10. "How would we create 30-50% FTE capacity for E-ITS within current team size?"

**Inter-University Cooperation:** 11. "What is EKA's engagement level with Estonian universities' IT cooperation working groups?" 12. "Has EKA learned from other universities' E-ITS implementations?"

**Priorities & Timeline:** 13. "Given E-ITS is mandatory, what is the university's compliance timeline expectation?" 14. "How does security rank among priorities like T4EU infrastructure and digital transformation?" 15. "Are there external drivers (audits, partnerships) creating E-ITS urgency?" 16. "Why is Kenet leaving? (Is E-ITS pressure a factor?)"

### **Red Flags to Watch:**

- "We need you to implement E-ITS quickly" (unrealistic - 2.5-4 years minimum)
- "This is IT department responsibility" (wrong - requires organizational commitment)

- “No budget for consultants or additional staff” (proper implementation needs resources)
- “Security shouldn’t interfere with academic freedom” (cultural resistance)
- “Previous IT head didn’t mention E-ITS” (institution may be significantly behind)

#### **Green Flags to Look For:**

- “Rector/board has discussed information security strategy” (management awareness)
- “We’ve started GDPR work with Bert Blös” (foundation exists)
- “We’re open to external consultants” (realistic about expertise gaps)
- “We participate in inter-university IT cooperation” (collaborative, learning mindset)
- “We understand this is multi-year journey” (realistic expectations)

## **2. Digital Development Strategy**

**Challenge:** The job posting specifically mentions “IT digiarendusstrateegia ning tegevusplaanide väljatöötamine ja elluviimine” as a core responsibility.

#### **Context:**

- Educational institutions undergoing massive digital transformation
- Post-COVID acceleration of digital services
- AI tools revolutionizing education and creative work
- Student/faculty expectations evolved significantly

#### **Areas to Address:**

- **Teaching & Learning:** Moodle enhancement, digital assessment tools, collaboration platforms
- **Research Support:** Data management, digital archives, research infrastructure
- **Administrative Efficiency:** Process automation, self-service portals, workflow optimization
- **Creative Tools:** Software licensing (Adobe, Autodesk, etc.), render farms, specialized hardware
- **Accessibility:** Digital accessibility standards, inclusive design
- **Data Analytics:** Student success metrics, operational dashboards
- **AI Integration:** Responsible AI use in education, creative AI tools, ethics

#### **Your Positioning:**

- Experience developing technical strategies (PÖFF platform architecture)
- Understanding of user needs analysis (700+ diverse users at EKA before)
- Stakeholder management (faculty, students, administration, vendors)
- Practical implementation focus (delivery track record)

## **3. Team Leadership & Development**

#### **Unknown Variables:**

- Current IT team size and composition □ (5 people identified)
- **Team capacity: reactive vs. strategic work split (CRITICAL TO ASSESS)**
- **Infrastructure responsibilities: who actually does sysadmin work?**
- **Bert Blös integration level: full IT team member or semi-independent?**
- Team morale and capability levels

- Skill gaps in current team
- Why previous head left (burnout risk indicator)

### Your Strengths:

- 6 years combined IT team/department leadership
- 100% intern success rate (PÖFF team)
- Experience building teams from scratch
- Cross-functional coordination experience

### Risk Scenario to Validate:

If the 3-person “support” team is actually doing full infrastructure/sysadmin work AND Bert operates semi-independently, you’re inheriting a team with **zero strategic project capacity**. Every minute is consumed keeping systems running.

### Implications if True:

1. **Job description ambitions unrealistic without team growth**
2. **You become hands-on operator, not strategic leader**
3. **E-ITS, digital transformation, T4EU infrastructure = 100% YOUR personal workload**
4. **Previous head may have left due to impossible expectations**

### Assessment Strategy:

- Ask directly about time allocation (reactive vs. strategic)
- Request examples of recent strategic projects
- Probe on infrastructure management responsibilities
- Understand Bert’s reporting structure and daily work
- Clarify budget for additional headcount
- Ask why Kenet is leaving (honest answer reveals much)

**Decision Point:** If team is fully saturated with no capacity and no growth budget, this role becomes **unsustainable** without either:

- Additional headcount approval
- Significant external vendor support
- Reduced scope expectations
- Your willingness to do 60-80 hour weeks

### Current IT Department Team (5 people):

1. **Kenet Pindmaa** - IT-osakonna juhataja (Head of IT Department)
  - Email: kenet.pindmaa@artun.ee
  - *Current role holder - predecessor/context*

### Support/Operations Team (3 people - helpdesk/user support):

2. **Robert Luig** - IT vanemspetsialist (IT Senior Specialist)
  - Email: robert.luig@artun.ee, Phone: +372 6267 339
  - *Senior support role - likely team lead for daily operations*
3. **Alan Aleksander Antriainen** - IT spetsialist (IT Specialist)
  - Email: alan.antriainen@artun.ee
  - *No public profile details available (minimal EKA page)*
  - **Historical connection:** Likely related to Olga Antriainen (your learning systems specialist 2009-2012)

- *Olga's EKA profile now returns 404 - she no longer works there*
  - *"Antriainen" is uncommon Estonian surname - strong indicator of family relation*
4. **Mark Erik Tina** - IT-spetsialist (IT Specialist)
- Email: mark.tina@artun.ee

#### **Specialized Role:**

5. **Bert Blös** - Andmekaitse spetsialist (Data Protection Specialist)
- Email: bert.blos@artun.ee
  - *GDPR/data protection - critical for E-ITS implementation!*

#### **Team Analysis:**

- **Small team:** 5 people supporting 1,144 students + 279 employees (~280 users per IT staff)
- **Customer support focus:** 3-person support team handling helpdesk, user issues, daily operations
- **Data protection specialist:** Bert Blös = excellent foundation for E-ITS work
- **Structure:** 1 head + 3 support specialists + 1 data protection specialist
- **Missing roles?** No dedicated system administrator, developer, or infrastructure specialist visible
- **Historical connection:** Alan Antriainen may be related to Olga Antriainen (your 2009-2012 learning systems specialist)

#### **CRITICAL CONCERN - Team Capacity Reality:**

##### **Potential Scenario (RISK):**

- 3-person "support" team actually fully occupied with infrastructure maintenance/system administration
- Bert Blös (data protection) semi-independent, only nominally attached to IT department
- Result: **ZERO spare capacity for strategic initiatives, digital transformation, or E-ITS**

##### **If This is True:**

- You're inheriting a fully saturated team doing bare minimum to keep lights on
- Any strategic work (digital strategy, E-ITS, T4EU infrastructure) falls entirely on YOU
- No team capacity to delegate projects to - you become hands-on operator, not strategic leader
- Digital transformation ambitions in job description may be unrealistic without team growth

##### **This Would Explain:**

- Why position is vacant (previous head burned out from operational overload?)
- Why no visible infrastructure/sysadmin roles (everyone's doing infrastructure)
- Why E-ITS hasn't progressed (no capacity for compliance projects)
- Small team size relative to institution scale and ambitions

#### **MUST ASSESS DURING INTERVIEW - See Critical Questions Below**

##### **Key Questions:**

##### **Questions to Ask:**

- **Why is Kenet Pindmaa leaving?** (Retirement? Better opportunity? Burnout?)

- **CRITICAL: What percentage of the team's time is spent on reactive support vs. infrastructure maintenance vs. strategic projects?**
- **How much of Robert/Alan/Mark's time is infrastructure/sysadmin work vs. user support?**
- **Is Bert Blös fully integrated into IT department or operating semi-independently?**
- **What does Bert's typical week look like? How much time on IT projects vs. institutional data protection?**
- **Who manages servers, networks, system updates, security patches if the support team is handling users?**
- **What external vendors/consultants handle specialized IT needs? (Infrastructure? Development? Security?)**
- **What happened to learning systems role (Olga Antriainen 2009-2012)?**
- **When was the last time the team completed a strategic project (not urgent firefighting)?**
- What are individual team members' areas of expertise beyond support?
- What is the biggest challenge the team faces today?
- What are the growth and development opportunities for team members?
- **If I want to implement digital transformation strategy, where does that capacity come from?**
- **Is there budget for additional headcount or must I work with current team size?**

#### **4. Legacy Infrastructure Management**

**Challenge:** Understanding what survived from 2012 and what needs modernization.

##### **Infrastructure You Built (2012):**

- Campus LAN (likely upgraded but topology may remain)
- Google Workspace (confirmed still in use!)
- Entu platform (unknown if still active)

##### **Questions to Explore:**

- What parts of the 2012 infrastructure are still in production?
- What technical debt exists?
- What are the most frequent user complaints?
- What systems are reaching end-of-life?
- What capital investments are planned?

#### **5. Budget & Resource Constraints**

##### **Public Sector Reality:**

- Limited IT budgets
- Procurement regulations
- Long approval cycles
- Must demonstrate value/ROI

##### **Your Experience:**

- 90% email cost reduction (2012 - strong ROI story)
- Public sector experience (Justiitsministerium)
- Procurement system understanding (recent riigihanked research project)

##### **Approach:**

- Emphasize pragmatic, cost-effective solutions
- Track record of delivering on budget
- Understanding of public procurement (“soovitavalt” requirement)

## 6. Inter-University IT Cooperation

**Job Requirement:** “ülikoolide vahelises IT koostöö töörühmades osalemine”

### Estonian University IT Landscape:

- University of Tartu (largest)
- Tallinn University
- Tallinn University of Technology
- Estonian Music and Theatre Academy
- Shared challenges, shared solutions potential

### Opportunities:

- E-ITS implementation knowledge sharing
- Joint procurement (software licenses)
- Security incident response coordination
- Technical staff training and development
- System integration (student exchange, credit transfer)

### Your Positioning:

- Experience working with diverse stakeholders
  - Understanding of collaborative benefits
  - Previous university IT experience
  - Communication skills strong
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## Institutional Knowledge Advantages

### Deep Context Understanding (2009-2012)

#### Organizational Culture:

- Creative, artistic environment with unique IT needs
- Faculty autonomy and resistance to standardization
- Students with diverse technical literacy
- Administration focused on academic mission
- Resource constraints typical of public universities

#### Stakeholder Dynamics:

- Faculty priorities: teaching tools, research support, minimal disruption
- Students: reliable Wi-Fi, printing, software access, portfolio tools
- Administration: compliance, reporting, cost control
- Facilities: physical infrastructure coordination
- External partners: vendors, other universities, Ministry

#### Historical Challenges:

- Getting faculty buy-in for new systems

- Supporting specialized creative software and hardware
- Balancing security with accessibility for art students
- Limited IT budget vs high expectations
- Seasonal workload (admissions, graduations)

### **What Likely Hasn't Changed:**

- Need for reliable, fast network (large files in design/art)
  - Specialized lab requirements (rendering, printing, CNC machines)
  - Diverse user base (18-year-old students to 70-year-old professors)
  - Project-based work requiring collaboration tools
  - Portfolio and exhibition support needs
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## **Your Competitive Advantages**

### **1. Proven Institutional Fit**

#### **Unique Situation:**

- Only candidate who previously held this exact role
- Successfully delivered major projects in this environment
- Understand EKA's culture, politics, and constraints
- Existing relationships may still exist (13 years later - some staff remain)

#### **Infrastructure Legacy:**

- Google Workspace migration still serving institution
- LAN infrastructure topology likely based on your 2012 design
- Institutional memory of successful project delivery

### **2. Complete Technical Qualification**

#### **100% Match on Requirements:**

- ☐ IT education (computer science background)
- ☐ 3+ years IT experience (20+ years)
- ☐ 2+ years IT team leadership (6 years total)
- ☐ Native Estonian + C2 English
- ☐ Server/system architecture expertise
- ☐ Initiative, precision, reliability demonstrated
- ☐ Excellent communication and teamwork skills

#### **Only Gaps:**

- E-ITS (acknowledged, learnable)
- Riigihangete formal knowledge (preferred, not required)

### **3. Diverse Technical Background**

#### **Full Stack Understanding:**

- Infrastructure (LAN, servers, cloud)
- Applications (full-stack development)

- Databases (PostgreSQL, MySQL, Oracle, MongoDB)
- System architecture (30+ organizations)
- Security (general IT security practices)

#### **Modern Tech Stack:**

- Node.js/JavaScript (15 years)
- Python (current projects)
- Docker/Cloud (AWS experience)
- CI/CD (GitHub Actions)
- AI tools (since April 2024)

### **4. Leadership & Mentorship Track Record**

#### **Team Development:**

- 4-person PÖFF team: 100% permanent placement rate
- Hired all as interns, developed into full developers
- Created supportive learning environment
- Practical mentorship approach

#### **Project Delivery:**

- All major EKA projects delivered on time/budget (2012)
- PÖFF festival platform (3 years continuous operation)
- Large-scale migrations (zero downtime)
- Risk management success

### **5. Recent Public Sector Understanding**

#### **Current Context:**

- Riigihanked research project (November 2025 - analyzing procurement API)
- Understanding of modern Estonian digital government services
- Awareness of E-ITS requirements (job research)
- Knowledge of TARA authentication system
- Contemporary security landscape awareness

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## **Interview Strategy**

### **Opening Positioning**

#### **First 2 Minutes:**

“Thank you for inviting me back to EKA. This position is unique for me - I held this exact role from 2009 to 2012, and I’m excited about the opportunity to return. The Google Workspace environment I migrated the university to is still in use today, and I imagine parts of the network infrastructure I built are still serving students and faculty.

Since 2012, I’ve continued developing both my technical skills and leadership experience - most recently leading a 4-person development team at PÖFF, where all my interns went on to permanent positions. I’ve also kept up with modern technologies including cloud architecture, AI tools, and contemporary security practices.

I'm particularly interested in this role because I understand EKA's culture, challenges, and unique needs as an art and design institution. I know how to balance security and compliance with the creative freedom that faculty and students need."

### **Core Messages to Convey**

**Message 1: Institutional Fit** "I've already proven I can succeed in this exact role at this exact institution. I understand EKA's culture, challenges, and stakeholder dynamics."

**Message 2: Growth Since 2012** "In 13 years, I've significantly expanded my technical and leadership capabilities. I'm not the same person who left - I'm better."

**Message 3: Practical Delivery Focus** "I focus on practical solutions that work. My track record shows consistent on-time, on-budget delivery with measurable results."

**Message 4: Learning Mindset** "I acknowledge gaps like E-ITS implementation, but I have a strong foundation and I'm committed to learning. I'll work with experts and leverage inter-university cooperation."

**Message 5: Long-term Commitment** "I'm not looking for a stepping stone. I want to build something sustainable at an institution I care about."

### **Addressing Potential Concerns**

#### **Concern 1: "You left in 2012. Why come back?"**

"I left to expand my technical skills and gain more diverse experience. I worked in telecom, software development, led a development team at Estonia's largest film festival, and built systems for 30+ organizations. Now I want to bring all that experience back to an institution I care about and apply modern approaches to the challenges EKA faces today. The difference is - in 2012, I was learning on the job. Now I'm bringing proven capabilities."

#### **Concern 2: "What about the 13-year gap? Things have changed."**

"Absolutely, and that's part of why I'm excited. The fundamentals I understand - EKA's culture, stakeholder needs, academic calendar, physical infrastructure constraints - those haven't changed. But the technology has evolved tremendously, and I've stayed current. I've worked with cloud platforms, modern security practices, AI tools, and contemporary development methodologies. I'm bringing both institutional knowledge and current technical skills."

#### **Concern 3: "You don't have E-ITS experience."**

"That's correct, and I want to be direct about it. I have strong general IT security experience - I managed security for a university network, worked with sensitive data at Justiitsministeerium, and understand risk management. But E-ITS as a specific framework is new to me."

My approach would be to:

1. Work with external E-ITS consultants initially
2. Learn from other Estonian universities who have implemented it
3. Participate actively in inter-university IT cooperation working groups
4. Build internal capability over time

I'm not someone who pretends to know everything. I learn fast, and I'm committed to getting this right."

#### Concern 4: "Why should we choose you over other candidates?"

"Three reasons: First, I've already succeeded in this exact role at EKA - I have a proven track record here. Second, I understand EKA's unique needs as an art institution - you need IT leadership that balances security with creativity, compliance with flexibility. Third, I care about EKA's mission. This isn't just another IT job for me - it's an opportunity to contribute to Estonian arts education."

#### Questions to Ask (Priority Order)

##### Immediate Context:

1. "What are the biggest IT challenges EKA is facing right now?"
2. **"Can you describe a typical week for the IT team? How much time is reactive support vs. strategic projects?"**
3. **"Who handles infrastructure and system administration - servers, networks, security patches, updates?"**
4. "What does the current IT department look like - team size, roles, capabilities?"
5. **"Is Bert Blös (data protection) fully integrated into IT department operations or does he work more independently?"**
6. "What happened to the infrastructure I built in 2012? What's still in use, what's been replaced?"
7. **"Why is Kenet Pindmaa leaving? What can I learn from his experience in the role?"**

**Strategic Direction:** 4. "What are EKA's strategic priorities for IT over the next 3-5 years?" 5. "Where is EKA in the E-ITS implementation process? What's the timeline and budget?" 6. "How does EKA's IT strategy align with the broader digital transformation in Estonian higher education?"

**Stakeholder Dynamics:** 7. "How has faculty and student feedback on IT services been? What are the main pain points?" 8. "What is the relationship like with external IT vendors and partners?" 9. "How does EKA participate in inter-university IT cooperation? What value does it bring?"

**Resources & Support:** 10. "What budget and resources are available for IT initiatives?" 11. "What support can I expect from executive leadership for IT initiatives?" 12. "What opportunities exist for professional development and training for the IT team?"

**Culture & Expectations:** 13. "What would success look like in the first 6 months? First year?" 14. "What caused the previous IT-osakonna juhataja to leave?" 15. "What aspects of the role do you think will be most challenging?"

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#### Day-of-Interview Logistics

##### Practical Preparation

##### Location:

- **Address:** Põhja pst 7, 10412 Tallinn (EKA Kalamaja building)
- **Room:** D206.1 (Personnel Department, 2nd floor)
- **Arrival:** Arrive 10-15 minutes early (9:45-9:50)

- **Building familiarity:** THIS IS A NEW BUILDING (moved after 2012!) - different from where I worked

### **Materials to Bring:**

- ☐ Copy of CV (Estonian version)
- ☐ Copy of motivation letter
- ☐ Notepad and pen for notes
- ☐ List of prepared questions
- ☐ Portfolio/examples (if relevant - GitHub profile, project screenshots)
- ☐ References list (if requested)

### **Technical Prep:**

- ☐ Phone fully charged (for emergencies)
- ☐ Confirmation email accessible
- ☐ Marika's contact info saved (+372 6267 306)
- ☐ Backup transportation plan

### **Interview Panel Possibilities**

#### **Likely Attendees:**

- Marika Kopõlova (HR Specialist) - confirmed
- Rector or Vice-Rector (strategic oversight)
- Current IT staff member (technical assessment)
- Faculty representative (user perspective)
- Administration representative (budget/compliance)

#### **Adapt to Panel:**

- HR: Focus on cultural fit, team dynamics, leadership style
- Executive: Strategic vision, alignment with EKA mission
- Technical: Problem-solving approach, technical competency
- Faculty: Understanding of user needs, communication style
- Admin: Budget awareness, compliance understanding

### **Post-Interview**

#### **Immediate Follow-up:**

- Thank you email within 24 hours
- Reiterate key strengths and interest
- Address any questions left unanswered
- Provide additional information if requested

#### **Timeline Expectations:**

- Decision timeline unknown - ask during interview
  - Multiple interview rounds possible
  - Reference checks likely
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## Red Flags to Watch For

### Warning Signs

#### Organizational:

- Extremely high IT staff turnover
- Unrealistic expectations for role scope (**ASSESS: team capacity vs. strategic ambitions**)
- No clear strategy or direction
- Budget constraints making role impossible
- Political dysfunction or unclear reporting lines
- **Team fully saturated with no capacity for strategic work**
- **Previous head left due to burnout/impossible workload**

#### Cultural:

- Resistance to change overwhelming
- No support from leadership for IT initiatives
- Blame culture when systems fail
- No investment in staff development

#### Technical:

- Critical systems at end-of-life with no replacement plan
- Major security vulnerabilities with no urgency
- Outdated infrastructure that can't support modern needs
- Complete lack of documentation
- **Infrastructure held together with duct tape, consuming all team capacity**

#### Resource Red Flags:

- **No budget for additional headcount despite ambitious strategic goals**
- **Data protection specialist semi-independent, not available for IT projects**
- **All 3 support staff doing infrastructure/sysadmin, not support**
- **Job description promises strategy but reality is firefighting**

**If Red Flags Appear:** Use questions to assess severity and decision-makers' awareness. Consider whether you can drive change or if situation is untenable. **Pay special attention to team capacity vs. role expectations mismatch** - this is the #1 burnout predictor.

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## Stress Scenarios & Responses

### Scenario 1: "Your E-ITS gap is concerning"

**Response:** "I understand that concern. Let me be clear about my approach: I don't implement standards I don't fully understand. My plan would be:

Phase 1 (Months 1-3): Partner with an experienced E-ITS consultant, conduct gap analysis, create implementation roadmap.

Phase 2 (Months 4-12): Work hands-on with consultant to implement, document everything, build internal knowledge.

Phase 3 (Year 2+): Take full ownership, maintain compliance, train team.

I've successfully implemented complex systems I wasn't initially expert in - Google Workspace migration in 2012, Entu platform - by following this learn-implement-own pattern. The key is being honest about what you don't know and bringing in the right expertise."

### **Scenario 2: "Why should we hire you when you left before?"**

**Response:** "Fair question. In 2012, I had accomplished what I set out to do - built the infrastructure, migrated systems, established processes. At that point, I needed to grow in areas EKA couldn't provide - large-scale development, diverse technical challenges, team leadership at scale.

I've now done that. I've led development teams, built systems for 30+ organizations, worked across multiple technical stacks, and gained the breadth of experience needed to lead EKA's IT strategy for the next decade.

The difference between 2012 and now is maturity and capability. I'm ready to commit long-term to building something sustainable, not just implementing one-off projects."

### **Scenario 3: "We need someone who can start immediately with E-ITS"**

**Response:** "If E-ITS implementation is the absolute top priority starting day one, then you should understand my learning curve. However, consider:

1. E-ITS implementation is typically a 12-18 month process - nobody truly 'starts immediately'
2. I can hire consultants and begin the process within the first month
3. My institutional knowledge means I won't waste time learning EKA's systems, politics, and processes
4. I'll be productive on other priorities (team leadership, strategy, operations) from day one

If you need someone who's implemented E-ITS five times before, I'm not that person. If you need someone who can successfully lead the implementation while also managing all other IT responsibilities, I'm highly qualified."

### **Scenario 4: "The budget is very limited"**

**Response:** "I've operated in constrained budget environments my entire career - public sector, startups, nonprofits. In 2012, I reduced email costs by 90% while improving service. At PÖFF, we built a festival platform on minimal budget.

My approach:

- Prioritize ruthlessly (what actually moves the needle?)
- Leverage open source and cost-effective cloud services
- Build vs buy analysis (sometimes building is cheaper)
- Incremental improvement over big-bang projects
- Measure and demonstrate ROI

Limited budget isn't a dealbreaker - unclear priorities and lack of leadership support are. If we're aligned on goals, I can work within tight constraints."

## **30/60/90 Day Plan (If Asked)**

### **First 30 Days: Listen & Learn**

#### **Goals:**

- Understand current state
- Build relationships
- Identify urgent issues
- Quick wins

#### **Activities:**

- Meet with every IT team member individually
- Interview key stakeholders (faculty, admin, students)
- Audit current systems and infrastructure
- Review documentation (what exists)
- Assess E-ITS readiness
- Identify top 3 urgent issues
- Deliver 1-2 quick wins (e.g., fix long-standing annoyance)

**Deliverable:** 90-day roadmap based on findings

### **First 60 Days: Plan & Prioritize**

#### **Goals:**

- Develop IT strategy
- Begin E-ITS process
- Address urgent issues
- Build team capability

#### **Activities:**

- Draft IT digital development strategy
- Engage E-ITS consultant, begin gap analysis
- Launch 1-2 priority projects
- Establish regular stakeholder communication
- Participate in first inter-university IT meeting
- Review vendor contracts and relationships
- Implement quick security improvements
- Begin team training/development

**Deliverable:** Approved IT strategy and budget proposal

### **First 90 Days: Execute & Stabilize**

#### **Goals:**

- Demonstrate value
- Build momentum
- Establish credibility
- Set foundation for long-term

#### **Activities:**

- Complete E-ITS gap analysis and roadmap

- Deliver 2-3 visible improvements
- Establish regular IT service reporting
- Implement priority security measures
- Build documentation practices
- Create IT department goals for year
- Establish innovation pipeline
- Foster team cohesion

**Deliverable:** Quarterly report to leadership with metrics and progress

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## Success Metrics (First Year)

### Operational Excellence

- **System uptime:** 99.5%+ for critical systems
- **Support ticket resolution:** 90%+ within SLA
- **User satisfaction:** Measurable improvement in faculty/student surveys
- **Security incidents:** Zero major breaches, documented incident response process

### Strategic Progress

- **E-ITS:** Gap analysis complete, implementation roadmap approved, Phase 1 underway
- **IT Strategy:** Documented, approved, resourced digital development strategy
- **Team:** Clear roles, development plans, improved morale (measured)
- **Budget:** Demonstrated ROI on key initiatives, secured resources for year 2

### Stakeholder Value

- **Faculty:** At least 3 new tools/services supporting teaching/research
  - **Students:** Improved digital experience (faster Wi-Fi, better labs, easier access)
  - **Administration:** Better reporting, compliance progress, cost optimization
  - **Partnerships:** Active participation in inter-university cooperation with tangible benefits
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## Personal Mindset

### Confidence Anchors

1. **I've done this job before at this institution - successfully.**
2. **I have 13 additional years of growth since then.**
3. **I'm a 100% match on required qualifications.**
4. **I genuinely care about EKA's mission.**
5. **I have nothing to prove and nothing to hide.**

## Authenticity Principles

- Be honest about gaps (E-ITS)
- Don't oversell or make promises I can't keep
- Show genuine enthusiasm for the work
- Acknowledge challenges realistically
- Demonstrate problem-solving thinking, not just technical knowledge

## Energy Management

- **Get good sleep the night before**
  - **Eat a proper breakfast**
  - **Arrive calm and centered**
  - **Remember: they need someone good, I am good at this**
  - **This is a conversation, not a test**
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## Final Checklist

### Knowledge Preparation

- ☒ Understand current EKA context
- ☒ Identify key challenges and gaps
- ☒ Prepare responses to likely questions
- ☒ Develop strategy for first 90 days
- ☒ Research E-ITS requirements
- ☒ Compile relevant examples and stories

### Materials Preparation

- ☐ Print CV and motivation letter
- ☐ Prepare portfolio/examples (if relevant)
- ☐ Write down key questions to ask
- ☐ Prepare notepad for taking notes

### Logistics

- ☐ Confirm interview time and location
- ☐ Plan transportation (arrive early)
- ☐ Professional attire prepared
- ☐ Phone charged, backup contacts saved

### Mental Preparation

- ☐ Review confidence anchors
  - ☐ Visualize successful interview
  - ☐ Practice key opening statement
  - ☐ Get good rest the night before
  - ☐ Morning routine to arrive energized
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## Closing Thoughts

This is not just another job interview - it's an opportunity to return to an institution you care about, in a role you've proven you can excel at, with significantly more experience and capability than before.

**Your job in this interview is to:**

1. **Show them who you are now** (not who you were in 2012)
2. **Demonstrate you understand the challenges** (E-ITS, digital strategy, team leadership)
3. **Prove you can deliver** (track record, specific examples, practical plans)
4. **Convey genuine commitment** (this isn't a stepping stone)

**Remember:**

- You're evaluating them as much as they're evaluating you
- Be yourself - authenticity wins
- Focus on value you bring, not gaps you have
- Show enthusiasm without desperation

**You've got this.** You're not trying to convince them you might be good - you're showing them you are good, with proof.

Good luck, and bring that calm confidence that comes from knowing you can actually do the job.

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**Document created:** 2025-12-25

**Interview date:** 2026-01-06 at 10:00

**Location:** EKA, Põhja pst 7, II korrus, D206.1